Innovation Ecosystem Management

Why Successful Collaboration Requires More Than Finding the Right Partners

A strategic perspective for business and innovation leaders

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Executive Perspective

Innovation increasingly depends on knowledge, capabilities and resources beyond the boundaries of individual organisations. Suppliers, customers, universities, startups and sometimes competitors contribute to new products, services and business models.

Yet a bilateral innovation partnership is not necessarily an innovation ecosystem. An ecosystem exists where a value proposition depends on complementary contributions and interdependent activities across several independent actors. Some relationships remain stable; others change as opportunities emerge.

The leadership challenge is enabling independent organisations to create value collectively without relying on a single organisational hierarchy.

This paper examines why ecosystems are complex, where conventional partnership instruments fall short, and how leaders can combine governance, mutual commitment and interpersonal trust to sustain co-creation.

1. Recognising the Challenges

Organisations increasingly participate in research programmes, innovation hubs and industry networks. Some establish extensive partner portfolios. Yet activity and collaboration do not guarantee collective value creation.

Common symptoms include partnerships producing ideas but few viable outcomes; overlapping initiatives with different participants; unclear interdependencies; conflicting commercial and intellectual-property interests; unequal influence; different investment horizons and stakeholder obligations; cultural misunderstandings; and project teams unable to secure resources from their respective organisations.

Clearer contracts, responsibilities and project controls can address some problems. They cannot, by themselves, reconcile independent organisations whose priorities and relationships may change.

The fundamental question is how leaders create the conditions for sustained co-creation among actors who cannot simply be instructed to follow a common strategy.

2. Understanding the Underlying Tensions

Stable partnerships versus dynamic ecosystem relationships

A bilateral partnership can be organised around two parties, a shared objective and defined responsibilities. An ecosystem requires alignment among several interdependent contributions. Participants may work in different configurations across initiatives, while some relationships remain central for years.

Management must distinguish the stable relationships essential to value creation from the flexibility needed to engage new capabilities and partners. A network of agreements is not necessarily a functioning ecosystem.

Collective value creation versus individual value capture

An ecosystem promises value that participants could not readily realise alone. Each organisation nevertheless needs a convincing return for its contribution, whether revenue, market access, learning or strategic position.

Benefits and bargaining power are rarely equal. A platform owner, dominant customer or holder of essential technology may shape access conditions and the distribution of value. Leaders must pursue collective potential while ensuring that participation remains worthwhile and legitimate for individual actors.

Shared ambition versus different stakeholder obligations

A listed company may face particular capital-market, disclosure and shareholder expectations. A family-owned business may prioritise independence and continuity. A startup may be constrained by financing and cash runway; a university by research and public-funding obligations.

None of these categories guarantees a particular time horizon or behaviour. What matters is understanding each partner's actual decision rights, accountability and room to commit resources. An attractive collective investment may still be difficult for an individual partner to approve.

Shared direction versus organisational autonomy

An ecosystem needs coordination but lacks a single hierarchy. A powerful orchestrator may control a platform or customer interface; in other cases leadership is distributed or varies by initiative.

The challenge is to align interdependent activities without confusing influence with authority, and without assuming every participant will accept the same priorities.

Openness versus protection of strategic interests

Co-creation depends on knowledge exchange, while participants must protect intellectual property, confidential information and competitive advantage. Excessive protection obstructs learning; excessive openness creates unacceptable exposure.

Leaders need shared expectations about what can be exchanged, by whom, for which purpose and under which safeguards.

Cultural diversity versus shared ways of working

Organisations differ in decision speed, hierarchy, consultation, risk tolerance, communication and the role of formal agreements. Such differences reflect organisational history, ownership, industry and leadership as well as wider cultural influences. They cannot reliably be inferred from nationality.

One partner may view rapid decisions as commitment; another may regard broad consultation as the prerequisite for a credible decision. Direct challenge may be welcomed by one team and interpreted as a threat to relationships by another. Leaders should surface these assumptions and agree working principles without demanding cultural uniformity.

Formal agreements versus interpersonal trust

Contracts define rights and responsibilities, but trust is experienced between people. Leaders must believe that counterparts will behave transparently, honour commitments and engage constructively when unexpected difficulties arise.

An unforeseen technical problem or a change in investment needs tests this confidence more severely than routine progress does. Trust does not replace governance: relationships also need continuity beyond particular individuals and protection against changes in leadership.

The real test of trust is whether leaders believe they can resolve unforeseen difficulties together.

Ecosystem complexity therefore arises not merely from the number of partners, but from the interaction of dependencies, interests, power, governance obligations, cultural assumptions and personal relationships.

3. Why Conventional Approaches Are Not Always Enough

Managing bilateral relationships separately

Supplier management, alliances and joint ventures provide valuable disciplines. But excellent individual contracts do not guarantee that technical standards, service delivery, customer adoption and other complementary activities fit together. Ecosystem performance depends on the whole configuration.

Mistaking contractual certainty for resilience

Contracts cannot anticipate every discovery, market shift or change in resource requirements. A legally sound agreement may outlive its commercial assumptions. Formal protection must be combined with relationships and decision arrangements that enable adaptation.

Treating institutional differences as operational delays

Different approval cycles or disclosure obligations may reflect legitimate governance constraints rather than unwillingness. More meetings will not remove them. Leaders must distinguish coordination problems from constraints that partners cannot simply waive.

Assuming shared project authority

Milestones and work packages help organise collaboration, but a project plan cannot compel independent organisations to maintain commitments. Resources may be redirected even when the project remains technically sound. Management must sustain the conditions for cooperation, not only monitor its activities.

4. Rethinking the Management Approach

Shift 1: From managing partners to understanding the ecosystem landscape

Begin with the value proposition, the complementary activities required and the critical dependencies. Identify which participants are essential to each initiative and which configurations may change. This draws on the ecosystem-as-structure perspective: alignment matters more than partner count.

Shift 2: From negotiating deals to sustaining mutual commitment

Clarify both collective value and each partner's expected benefit, obligations and constraints. Revisit these assumptions as conditions change. Commitment is not secured permanently when an agreement is signed.

Shift 3: From contracts alone to trust supported by governance

Develop personal relationships among leaders and specialists through transparent discussion, credible behaviour and joint problem-solving. Support them with decision rights, escalation mechanisms and durable organisational agreements. Trust and governance are complementary, not substitutes.

Shift 4: From uniform control to adaptive governance

Decide what requires collective agreement, what teams can resolve and what remains subject to each partner's internal approval. Explicitly address decision speed, consultation, confidentiality and conflict resolution. Coordination should respect autonomy and differences in influence.

Shift 5: From formal cooperation to cross-organisational engagement

Enable engineers, commercial teams and other professionals to identify opportunities, challenge assumptions and learn together. Connect this initiative to clear authority and realistic resource commitments. Professional enthusiasm cannot compensate for organisational unwillingness to invest.

Figure 1. Innovation Ecosystem Management

Connecting ecosystem complexity with five leadership responses.



Conceptual synthesis for leadership discussion.

5. Implications for Management

Leaders should first ask whether an ecosystem is genuinely needed. Some innovations can be delivered internally or through a focused bilateral partnership. An ecosystem becomes relevant where several independent, complementary activities must be aligned.

Management must then understand not just partner capabilities but also relative influence, stakeholder obligations and the decision constraints that shape commitments. Governance should clarify dependencies, roles and escalation while leaving room for different organisational practices.

Building trust before it is tested

Personal confidence cannot be manufactured at the moment of crisis. It grows through repeated interaction, consistent behaviour and constructive resolution of smaller disagreements. Senior leaders should invest in relationships and candid conversations about interests and limits before unexpected difficulties arise.

The question is whether leaders know one another well enough to believe that difficult problems can be solved together, even when the original agreement provides only partial guidance.

Connecting employee initiative with organisational commitment

Cross-organisational teams often discover possibilities that senior management cannot see in advance. Their insights should shape decisions, not merely execute them. Yet teams also need clarity about confidentiality, decision rights and who can commit resources.

Meaningful involvement links distributed expertise to credible organisational choices. This is how trust and co-creation become more than executive rhetoric.

An illustrative management situation

Consider an industrial equipment manufacturer developing a circular service offering involving refurbishment, component recovery, digital product information and service contracts. It needs a listed technology supplier, privately owned service providers, a research institution and customers prepared to adopt a different ownership model.

The manufacturer initially manages these as separate bilateral relationships. Problems arise: the technology supplier requires internal approval for new investment, a service partner needs long-term assurances, and the research institution wants to publish findings. Partners also differ in how they consult, challenge proposals and make binding decisions.

When an unexpected technical problem requires additional resources, existing contracts offer only partial guidance. A better approach maps the shared value proposition and dependencies, recognises each actor's constraints, clarifies governance and uses trusted cross-organisational relationships to develop alternatives.

This is an illustrative scenario, not a documented company case.

6. Questions for the Leadership Team

1. Are we managing bilateral partnerships, or do we understand how complementary activities and actors must align to create ecosystem value?

2. Do we understand the interests, stakeholder obligations, cultural assumptions and relative influence shaping our partners' commitments?

3. Have we developed the personal relationships, trust and governance needed to resolve unforeseen difficulties together?

4. How do we involve employees across organisational boundaries in shaping opportunities and connect their initiative to credible organisational commitments?

Closing Perspective

Innovation ecosystem management is not measured by the number of partnerships established. Its value lies in enabling independent organisations to align capabilities, navigate differences and act together when no single actor controls the outcome.

A successful innovation ecosystem is not defined by who participates, but by what its participants become capable of creating together.

About the Author

Koen Klokgieters is the founder of InnoPlot and has spent more than three decades working at the intersection of strategy, innovation, technology and organisational transformation. His experience combines corporate leadership, consulting, entrepreneurship and education.

Through InnoPlot, he supports organisations and their leaders in translating strategic challenges into innovation capabilities, organisational change and measurable impact.

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Conceptual Foundations

The article combines established research on ecosystem structure, governance and interorganisational collaboration. Its five leadership shifts are an editorial synthesis for management discussion, not a validated universal model.

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